

The top 10 free/open source licences

The following section lists and then briefly explains the top 10 free/open source licences. The selection of a particular licence is not based on popularity alone but also on how strongly it represents its licence category, as well as its general usefulness to developers.

- GNU General Public License
- GNU Lesser General Public License
- Apache License
- BSD Licenses
- MIT License
- Creative Commons License
- Artistic License
- Mozilla Public License
- Common Public License
- Microsoft Public License

GNU General Public License

This is one of the most popular free and open source licences. In fact, it has become so popular that all the other licences are divided into two categories—licences which are compatible with GPL and those that are not. Two licences are considered compatible with each other if they can be used in a single project without violating the terms of one another. GPL is accepted by both the FSF and the OSI. It is a copyleft licence and often considered one of the strictest licences as far as freedom and openness of a project is considered. It does not allow proprietary projects to even dynamically link to free and open source modules. The only downside is that this licence is often overlooked by developers due to its alleged strictness with regard to software freedom. The latest version is GPL version 3. The Linux kernel and the GCC are examples of software using this licence.

GNU Lesser General Public License

The GNU LGPL is another very popular free and open source software licence. It is a weaker form of GPL. The main difference is with respect to the dynamic linking of shared libraries. LGPL allows proprietary software to dynamically link to shared libraries. Both FSF and OSI have approved the LGPL, making it a free and open source licence. LGPL is a copyleft licence. Both GPL and LGPL were created by the FSF itself. These two GPL family licences are used in almost half the software projects that were analysed by a company called Black Duck Software. This clearly shows the dominance of the GPL family of licences. LGPL is compatible with GPL and is mostly used to license libraries.

Apache License

This licence has been written by the Apache Software Foundation (ASF). Many studies show that Apache Licences are used by nearly a quarter of all the free/open source projects. The Apache License is approved

by both the FSF and the OSI, and it is widely considered a permissive licence. The FSF recommends the Apache License for projects with code less than 300 lines. The Apache License version 2 is compatible with GPL version 3. The Android operating system has adopted the Apache License.

BSD Licenses

BSD Licenses are a family of permissive licences proposed by the University of California, Berkeley. The original BSD License was used with the Berkeley Software Distribution (BSD), a UNIX-like operating system. The modified BSD License has the approval of both the FSF and the OSI, making it a free and open source software licence. The modified BSD License is also compatible with GPL version 3.

MIT License

The MIT License is a permissive licence proposed by the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). It is GPL compatible and is used by Ruby on Rails, jQuery, X Window System, etc. The MIT License is also approved by both the FSF and the OSI, making it a free and open source licence.

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Artistic License

Artistic License was originally created by Larry Wall, the creator of the Perl programming language, which uses this licence. The original version was intended to enforce FOSS-like licences by using contract law rather than copyright law. But the initiative was widely criticised by